12:47

Genre: Romantic Drama

Ivan Philips

ACT 1
SCENE 1

INT - DAY - CAFE

There are three tables, two of which have a couple seated. One look like they are making fun conversations, laugh occasionally, the other are mostly silent and keep to themselves only to fight when they open their mouth. They will be in the background and the lighting would be lighting up more of the the happy couple in the initial scenes but, slowly the brightness would shift towards the bickering couple once the tone in the play shifts and then both are lit up equally.

We see a woman seated at a table in the centre, reading a book and having her coffee. The doorbell jingles. She looks up and after there is no sign of anyone entering, she looks back down into her book and takes a sip of her coffee. A waitress walks by and stops at her table.

WAITRESS
Is the coffee alright? Would you like to try something else?

WOMAN
(looking up at the waitress)
Oh it's wonderful, I think I’m good.

WAITRESS
Well if you need anything just call me.

The waitress leaves. The doorbell jingles. The woman perks up and looks towards the entrance. A man walks in. He is looking around for someone and smiles when his eyes fall on her. The woman puts her book down. They hug.

MAN
Hi!

WOMAN
Hi.

MAN
(Counting on his fingers)

How long has it been? Since we last met? Has it been seven, or eight years now?

WOMAN
Eight I think . Wow, almost a decade huh..

MAN
Sounds unreal when we say it out loud.

WOMAN
Yeah… it does.

MAN
How have you been?

WOMAN
I’ve been.. Pretty good. How about you and your parents?

MAN
Oh, I've been doing okay mostly. They are doing quite well. They went back all the way to my mother's hometown, where my maternal grandmother grew upa and built a bungalow there.

WOMAN
Oh wow, that must have, costed a lot!

MAN
Yeah I never knew that they had that kind of money saved up, my father probably hit it big in the stock market I believe.. How is your sister doing by the way?

WOMAN
She’s doing well actually, she finished her degree abroad and got married to Kunal a year after that. You remember Kunal right? They also just had a kid recently last month, so I guess I’m an aunt now! Reva is the cutest kid I've ever seen! You want to see?

The MAN nods his head , the WOMAN takes out her phone and shows some pictures.

WOMAN
I've only been able to see her once since she was born. I'll probably visit her at the end of this month. I can't wait!

MAN

Congratulations! Man! time just slips by and you don’t even realise it, it feels like yesterday when she used to help you sneak out on all those late night trips we used to go for.

WOMAN

The amount of times she has saved my skin, my parents would freak out if they ever find out the amount of times I used to sneak out of the house.

There is a pause

MAN

What have you been up to? The last time we met, I remember you were applying for medical colleges, what happened?

WOMAN

It was really difficult, it took me about two to three tries to get a decent percentage to apply for the college I wanted. Try three, I finally got in, after which I applied for residency and I just completed it a few months back.

MAN

So you’re a doctor now..

WOMAN

Yes

MAN

Specialised in?

WOMAN

Paediatrics.

MAN

That’s amazing. It makes a lot of sense though.. you’ve always liked kids, and even if you wouldn't have then, it always felt like you would choose a profession that has kids involved.

The WOMAN takes a sip of her coffee.

WOMAN

Do you still write anymore?

MAN

At work? Not so much. We mostly do recordings than actual ideating since the clients always have a very narrow perspective on a lot of things, so it's a bit difficult to get really creative with so many constraints and I…

WOMAN

No, I'm so sorry to cut you off but, I was asking if you still wrote anything personally. Your blogs stopped being regular a few years back and, I haven't been updated since so I was just thinking…

MAN

Oh, You used to follow that?

WOMAN

It used to be interesting.

MAN

Recently when I revisited some of my old stuff, they seemed pretentious and as if I was writing for gaining an audience and not myself.

WOMAN

A lot of your early stuff, yes but it got a lot better over the years you know. Why didn't you continue though?

MAN

I try to, usually whenever I’m not busy with other projects you know, I probably could be writing more than I do right now, I have been free for months, but you know me, I’ve always been lazy and I've had a writer's block since some time now, I've been in a slump for so long there's nothing I've found interesting enough to write about…

The MAN signals to the waiter.

WOMAN

Have you been in touch with anyone from back then? Gautam? Anika?..

MAN

No, not a lot of them since I lost my previous number a few years back and lost all of my contacts with it. I tried to look up everyone online, which was not easy by the way. I had met Mohit recently though, at a restaurant a few weeks back and he seemed to be doing so well for himself. Can you believe that he teaches now?

WOMAN
What?! No way! You're talking about Mohit Desai right?! What does he even teach?

MAN
Yeah! The one and only. He's teaching kids to dance. It's funny how even he ended up working with kids. He says that has been enjoying it though, and that's good for him I feel.

A waiter walks up to them with a menu in hand.

WAITER
What would you like sir?

MAN
(Looking through the menu)
Hmm.. I would like to go for a cold coffee please.

WAITER
Of course. And would you like to have anything with that? Something to eat? We've got sandwiches, pastries …

MAN
I think we're good for now unless..

The MAN looks at the WOMAN. She gestures no.

WAITER
Ok so just one cold coffee?

MAN
Yes please. Thank you.

WAITER
Alright I'll be back.

The waiter smiles and leaves.

MAN
It's been so long since I've been here, so much has changed, I didn't even recognise the entrance at all, the roads confused me.

WOMAN
The owner changed a few years back. They were about to close down but, one of the regulars had fallen in love with their spouse in here and ended up buying it off from the original owner and renovating it.

MAN
It's exactly the same how it was eight years ago. The inside atleast. It's how I remembered it to be. Makes you think about back then huh.

There's a pause

WOMAN
We had some good times, didn’t we? Did we have to let go of all that? Why did we even in the first place?

MAN
We did have a good run I would agree with you on that but, I think if we hadn’t done it then, we would have probably hated each other more than we currently do right now you know. It feels like it was meant to happen.

There is an awkward silence.

WOMAN
Do you ever wonder what we would be doing right now if everything had worked out the first time itself? Would we have been somewhere else right now, doing something else maybe watching a movie together or you know cooking in ‘our’ kitchen, you know things like that?

MAN
Like, visiting places like we always said we would? Amsterdam, Vienna, Tokyo ? Probably planning for our wedding? Of course I do a lot infact! At times it gets really overwhelming. It’s not really difficult to think about the what ifs. What if I had just made a drive down to where you were, What If I tried to win you back, What If I showed you that, I had changed, and

I understood things and I knew better now? But that is all they are, what ifs. They are different futures that exist now where me might have ended up together for a long time but who knows?

WOMAN
All we have is right now.

MAN
Yes! Exactly. We can't change the past. We can only be able to make the best of today and I think as human beings, it's enough.

The MAN stops. The WAITER arrives with the coffee

WAITER
Here's your cold coffee sir.

MAN
Thank you, could I get some sugar please?

WAITER
Sure.

The Waiter walks away.

WOMAN
Remember when we used to bunk college just to meet each other? Or the time we went to those open mic events? Do memories like that still cross your mind?

The MAN winces after taking a sip of his coffee.

MAN
Not all of them but a lot still remain. And the open mics? How on earth can I forget? It was the first time that I ever heard you sing, and I was mesmerised. I could get lost for hours just listening to your voice. It was one of the things I loved about you the most, amongst other things of course. I practically used to listen to your voice notes to sleep at one point.

There's a pause. The waiter brings sugar. The WOMAN sips her coffee.

MAN
(to waiter)
Thank you!

WOMAN
Why didn’t you call? What took you so long? Why now ?

The MAN tries to gather his thoughts.

SCENE 2
(FLASHBACK)

INT - UNKOWN - A ROOM DIVIDED INTO TWO.

The rest of the dialogues are in a voice over, while the actors act in silence in relation to the narration. One half of the stage is the MANS perspective and the other, the WOMANS.

MAN

I tried to, many many times. I used to dial out your number and I had so many things in my head but I never knew where or how to start, I didn’t know what words to use. I used to try and write it down but then I used to read it and feel stupid and then tear it up. There was no correct way to begin such conversations.

Pause

MAN
My thumb would hover over the dial button and my mind would go blank. I felt like I would choke up on greeting you. Hi, a simple two letter word, a single syllable was so difficult to say without getting overwhelmed.

WOMAN
What if I was waiting? What if I wanted you to call me? To ask me how I was doing? I spent days waiting for my to ring and everytime it did, I was disappointed that it wasn't you.

Fade out , voice over is played during the black out till the next scene starts.

SCENE 3
INT - DAY - CAFE

The MAN and WOMAN are seated like before.

MAN
How could I have known that! I would have never been able to know any of that! I could also ask you the same thing though couldn’t I!? Why didn’t ‘YOU’ call me, if you wanted me to, so badly?!

The WOMAN is silent. Pause. Sip coffee.

MAN
I had always wanted to ask but, I never knew how to put it across or ask it , casually, so let me just rip off the bandaid. Do you remember Samarth?

WOMAN
What about him?

MAN
Did you ever end up, liking him back? Cause he clearly was into you and I could always feel something was weird between you guys, although you insisted that y'all were just friends and there could be nothing between y'all, but … I just felt that I was being gaslight the whole time.

WOMAN
well there was this time when we weren't seeing each other and I did end up at his place but, there's nothing that happened between us, in the ways that you're thinking! He was just a friend If anything, our relationship drove a wedge into the friendship I had with him and, he ended up cutting all ties with me.

Silence.

MAN
When we met, at Anika's party, after we broke up, this was sometime in December I guess? you didn’t say a word, and I'm sure that you saw me walk in! You acted really cold and distant.

SCENE 4

INT - NIGHT - Party at someone's apartment.

Blackout, flashback. Scene of a party. MAN walks in with some friends . WOMAN is engaged in conversation with other people. The MAN walks past, the other people greet him as he walks by but the WOMAN just sips her drink until he leaves. blackout.

WOMAN
Are you talking about the one she threw when she was leaving the country?

MAN
Yeah the one where she had invited everyone, for that, plus Christmas.

WOMAN
We had broken up less than a month before that! I used to have tears in my eyes even at the thought of your name!

Same party scene but this time, the MAN is talking to his friends and she tries to approach him, but is unable to get closer to him as the group around him creaes a sort of barrier around him. She gets overwhelmed and starts to cry as her friends hug her. Blackout.

That day, You didn’t even seem to be approachable at all. It’s like there was this barrier around you.

MAN
I’m just saying that it could have been just a cordial hi! I wasn’t expecting a whole conversation! It just made the atmosphere awkward for everyone over there.

SCENE 5
INT - DAY - CAFE

The man and woman are seated like before.

WOMAN
I don’t get it?!

MAN
Anika and Gautam had broken up less than a few months before that, but they still hung out like best friends, all I’m saying is-

WOMAN
What has that got to do with what happened to us? Where does it make sense?

The MAN looks frustrated.

MAN
I.. I don’t know. It seemed that we were better in every other way than them and we couldn’t overcome something as simple as that, I..

WOMAN
Why do you still equate other people's relationships with what we had? They are so different, in so many ways!

MAN
I’m sorry but I was really really insecure! I didn’t want to lose the best thing I thought that I had! It's difficult not to compare with anyone around and it made sense back then?!

WOMAN
This is probably why it was a good decision that we went our separate ways, why couldn't you be satisfied with what we had or we were at that point in time? We were a different set of people!

There is a silence. The WOMAN sips her coffee.

MAN
It hurt, you know. I cried in the shower a week later when it hit me, like really really hit me. It felt weird when I realised that it was all over, done and dusted for good now. I wished that I could go back. I wished that I could have said things to make you stay.

WOMAN

Why?

MAN

I honestly believed that we could have made it work if we had just communicated better. I don’t think that we are unreasonable people. We were kids, we had our ego’s and our pride. They got in the way of something that could have been so easy to fix ! If only we had know better but, we lacked the experience and it was a moment of learning.

They take a sip of their coffee

MAN

(cont’d)

What hurt the most was, we promised, we promised to try and make it work as friends cause we said that we didn’t want to lose the friendship that we had, but you never put in the effort like I did. And then I used to see you post things online with other people and it felt like you were in a better place and didn’t need me, and you were happier! It felt like it was better that I was no more a part of your life anymore.

WOMAN

What?! What made you think that? I cried myself to sleep for three months straight! I couldn’t understand why at first? You never put in the time, when we were a thing. it felt like only I was putting in the effort for everything everytime. We had to shift because of my fathers work. I was in a new place, there were new people. It was hard for me to make friends, I didn’t have any friends till I had left home and had started college, and it didn't help that all my old friends were in a different city. I had nothing to do, no one to talk to. Happy? Not at all. I was really depressed! I know that things weren’t good for you but I wasn’t having a great time either!

MAN

I was going through it myself too! So cut me some slack when you ask me why I didn’t try to reach out. I know initially it might have seemed like I did not put in the efforts, but I did, I really did! It’s just difficult to show it every single time. I thought that there was an understanding that I still loved you every single day the same no matter what.

Silence rings. They sip their coffees in silence.

MAN

I still remember tiny details about you after all these years you know. Like your favourite song, flower, movie. I've tried to forget those things, eight years hasn't been enough for my heart to let it all go. I still feel like we could work much better now! I know that a part of you does it too, so why can't we just-

WOMAN

It was so long ago, we are practically different people now! I don't know the you that you are currently anymore, you're nothing like who you used to be! It's not the same at all!

MAN

I know that we aren't who we used to be, we've grown now, and had our own set of experiences. Can't we just start over? We're new people now. I would love to get to know the new you. What's the harm in that?

WOMAN

I have different priorities now!

MAN

I'm not saying we need to jump into a relationship straight away! We could start again as friends, hang out, spend some time together, just like we did before, and gradually see where it leads to!

WOMAN

I don't have the time, or the mental space, or energy for things like that in my life anymore, my work is the only thing that is the most important thing to me right now, and the only thing that matters to me! It's not going to change for the longest time!

There's silence.The Cafe doorbell rings. A couple walks in, looks around and leaves. They sip their coffee.

MAN

I still remember exactly how you used
to make cold coffee. I still use the same recipe to this day.
One part black coffee, three parts cream,

BOTH
And an ice filled mason jar.

They both smile. It’s a sad smile.

WOMAN
Have you.. Have you ever written about me?

MAN
In what context?

WOMAN
Is any character of yours based on me? Something like that?

MAN
Never explicitly. Certain characteristics perhaps but never a one to one recreation. It always felt wrong, after we..

WOMAN
Mhmm.

Pause

WOMAN
(cont’d)
I wasn’t going to pick up the call. I hesitated and I asked Aditi ‘should I take it? I mean it’s been so long since I've talked to him, 'What would he even want after all this time?’. You know what she said?

The MAN nods no.

WOMAN
She said that if it was you, I should pick it up because out of all the people from my past, you were one of the level headed ones. I know that you are a good person and, what we had was good while it lasted but, I would not want anything like that right now in my life.

MAN
You don't understand! I’ve spent eight long years trying to find ‘the one’ I met a lot of people, and I realised a bit too late that while I saw parts of you in them, I was trying to find you! All of you but there is only the one you that was

the right one for me! I had to call you up. I couldn't leave so many things left unsaid for so many years, not anymore. I'm tired of trying to find someone new.

The WOMAN covers her mouth.

MAN
(cont'd)
I spent so much of my life doing things, alone or with other people but I always used to think, I wish that I could have done those things with you. Talked about it with you. Get to know what you felt about it because.. Because it made me feel happy. It is so hard to feel that way about someone else. I know I wasn't the best person but I've learnt since then and we could work towards it now, I know in my heart that we are the right people for each other! I've not felt like this about anyone other than I felt about you! So why not a second chance? Why not do it over?!

WOMAN
I can't. It's way too late now! If you had asked me a few years ago maybe! Maybe I would have considered it but now, we have a whole other life that doesn't involve the other person at all and I just feel if we go back to being whatever we used to be, it would be worse than before. What's happened in the past, lets just let it stay in the past. Leave it and let it be as good as we remember it to be! There is no need to bring it back and ruin it to try something new!

MAN
At Least we didn't wait for twenty or thirty years to have this conversation hmm?

The WOMAN just stares at him and then starts packing her things, and gets up.

WOMAN
I won't love you the way I did anymore but, I will always cherish the moments that we spent. They are happy memories for me, let it be the same for you. Goodbye.

The woman walks towards the entrance, pauses, looks back, the MAN's back is turned to her he stares into the distance, she

leaves. The starting notes of the song play (TBW will be roughly 3-4 minutes and would play till the end)

SCENE 6

The MAN lingers on, finishes his coffee and calls for the waiter. The waiter comes, and he asks for the bill. Which he gestures that it has been paid for. He walks to the entrance, and looks back. Flashback (blackout and there is a spotlight on the table that they just sat at) a Young couple sits there having a fun time, they are seen talking and eating. Blackout again lights come back on and the man smiles and leaves with the last notes of the song. Blackout.

THE END